

Emotion Wheel Reference Card

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A comprehensive emotion wheel covering 72 emotions across 8 primary states — with guidance on using the wheel for self-awareness and communication.

72-Emotion Wheel

8 Primary States

Self-Awareness Guide

Communication Tips

72

emotions

8

primary states

5

awareness steps

5

communication tips

HOW TO USE THIS WHEEL

Start at the centre and work outward. The 8 inner segments are primary emotional states — broad, universal categories. The 64 outer segments are more specific, nuanced words within each primary state. Precision matters: naming what you feel as “frustrated” rather than a vague “angry” changes both how you understand it and how you communicate it to someone else.



Full Reference — All 72 Words

If any word on the wheel itself is hard to read at a glance, use this table as the full written reference.

Primary State	Nuanced Emotions
Joy	Happy, Content, Pleased, Delighted, Cheerful, Optimistic, Proud, Elated
Trust	Accepted, Secure, Respected, Valued, Loyal, Open, Admiring, Devoted
Fear	Anxious, Worried, Nervous, Insecure, Threatened, Overwhelmed, Panicked, Vulnerable
Surprise	Amazed, Astonished, Confused, Startled, Shocked, Curious, Bewildered, Speechless
Sadness	Disappointed, Discouraged, Lonely, Hurt, Grief-stricken, Gloomy, Regretful, Empty
Disgust	Disapproving, Judgmental, Repelled, Contemptuous, Revolted, Disdainful, Averse, Suspicious
Anger	Frustrated, Irritated, Resentful, Hostile, Furious, Jealous, Betrayed, Indignant
Anticipation	Eager, Hopeful, Interested, Expectant, Enthusiastic, Alert, Determined, Impatient

Self-Awareness Guide

Use this sequence any time you notice an emotion but can't immediately name it precisely.

- 1 Start at the centre, not the edge**
Notice the raw physical or emotional sensation first — tight chest, racing thoughts, low energy — before trying to name it precisely.
- 2 Identify the nearest primary emotion**
Ask which of the 8 primary states feels closest to what you're experiencing right now, even if it's not an exact match.
- 3 Move outward to find the precise word**
Scan that primary emotion's 8 nuanced words for the one that fits best — the difference between "irritated" and "furious" changes how you should respond to yourself.
- 4 Name it specifically, out loud or in writing**
Precisely naming an emotion measurably reduces its intensity — a well-documented effect sometimes called "affect labelling."
- 5 Notice if more than one applies**
Mixed emotions are normal — you can feel both "disappointed" and "hopeful" about the same situation at once.

Communication Application Tips

Precise emotional language doesn't just help you understand yourself — it changes how clearly others understand you.

- 1 Replace vague words with specific ones**
"I'm stressed" could mean anxious, overwhelmed, or resentful — each needs a different response from the person listening.
- 2 Use the wheel before a difficult conversation**
Identify precisely what you're feeling before you speak, so you communicate the real issue rather than a generic complaint.
- 3 Ask others which word fits, don't assume**
"It sounds like you might be feeling X — is that right, or is it something else?" invites correction rather than putting words in their mouth.
- 4 Separate the primary state from the story**
"I feel betrayed" names the emotion. "You always do this" adds a narrative that often escalates rather than clarifies.
- 5 Watch for disgust and contempt in conflict**
These are strong predictors of relationship breakdown when they appear repeatedly in disagreements — naming them early allows a course correction.

A NOTE ON PRACTICE

Emotional vocabulary is a skill that improves with deliberate use, not passive reading. Keep this wheel somewhere visible — on a desk, in a notes app — and refer to it in the moment, especially during the situations where you'd normally reach for a vague word like "fine" or "stressed."